

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1988-12-29

To the followers of Bahá'u'lláh in the United States of America

1 dear Bahá'í friends,

we have noticed with concern evidences of a confusion of attitudes

2 among some of the friends when they encounter difficulties in applying
3 Bahá'í principles to questions of the day. on the one hand, they acknowl-
4 edge their belief in Bahá'u'lláh and his teachings; on the other, they invoke
5 western liberal democratic practices when actions of Bahá'í institutions or
6 of some of their fellow Bahá'ís do not accord with their expectations. At
7 the heart of this confusion are misconceptions of such fundamental issues 59.5

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62 10as individual rights and freedom of expression in the Bahá'í community.

63 The source of the potential difficulties of the situation appears to us to be
64 an inadequacy of Bahá'í perspective on the part of both individual believers
65 and their institutions.

66 recognizing the immense challenge you face to resolve such confusion,

67 we pause to reflect with you on these issues in search of a context in which relevant
fundamental questions may be discussed and understood in the

68 community.

69 The extraordinary capacities of the American nation, as well as the su-
70 perb stewardship of the Bahá'í community within it, have repeatedly been
71 extolled in the writings of our faith. in his Tablets and utterances, 'Abdu'l-
72 Bahá, the center of the covenant, projected a compelling vision of the
73 world-embracing prospects of that richly endowed country. "The American

74 nation," he averred, "is equipped and empowered to accomplish that which
75 will adorn the pages of history, to become the envy of the world, and be

blest in both the east and the west for the triumph of its people."

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77 other assertion addressed to the bahá'í community itself, he uttered words

78 of transcendent importance: "... your mission," he affirmed, "is unspeak-

79 ably glorious. Should success crown your enterprise, America will assuredly evolve
into a center from which waves of spiritual power will emanate, and the throne of the
kingdom of god will, in the plenitude of its majesty and

glory, be firmly established."

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81 Shoghi effendi, in various statements, celebrated the remarkable achieve-

82 ments and potential glories of that specially blessed community, but was

83 moved to issue, in The Advent of Divine Justice, a profound warning which

84 is essential to a proper understanding of the relation of that bahá'í com-

85 munity to the nation from which it has sprung. "The glowing tributes,"

86 he solemnly wrote, "so repeatedly and deservedly paid to the capacity, the

87 spirit, the conduct, and the high rank, of the American believers, both

88 individually and as an organic community, must, under no circumstances, be
confounded with the characteristics and nature of the people from which god has raised
them up. A sharp distinction between that community and

89 that people must be made, and resolutely and fearlessly upheld, if we wish to give
due recognition to the transmuting power of the faith of bahá'u'lláh,

90 60-1. pup , p. 143.

91 60-2. Tdp , no. 11.11.60.2

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61 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

62 10in its impact on the lives and standards of those who have chosen to enlist

63 under his banner. otherwise, the supreme and distinguishing function of

64 his revelation, which is none other than the calling into being of a new

65 race of men, will remain wholly unrecognized and completely obscured."60-3

66 it is the far-reaching, transformative implications of this distinction which
 67 we especially invite you to contemplate.

68 The vantage point that gives us perspective and is the foundation of our
 69 belief and actions rests on our recognition of the sovereignty of god and
 70 our submission to his will as revealed by bahá'u'lláh, his supreme mani-
 71 festation for this promised day. To accept the prophet of god in his time
 72 and to abide by his bidding are the two essential, inseparable duties which
 73 each soul was created to fulfill. one exercises these twin duties by one's own
 74 choice, an act constituting the highest expression of the free will with which
 75 every human being has been endowed by an all-loving creator.

76 The vehicle in this resplendent Age for the practical fulfillment of these
 77 duties is the covenant of bahá'u'lláh; it is, indeed, the potent instrument
 78 by which individual belief in him is translated into constructive deeds. The
 79 covenant comprises divinely conceived arrangements necessary to preserve
 80 the organic unity of the cause. it therefore engenders a motivating power
 81 which, as the beloved master tells us, "like unto the artery, beats and pul-
 82 sates in the body of the world." "it is indubitably clear," he asserts, "that
 83 the pivot of the oneness of mankind is nothing else but the power of the covenant."

84 60-4 Through it the meaning of the word, both in theory and
 85 practice, is made evident in the life and work of 'Abdu'l-bahá, the appointed
 86 interpreter, the perfect exemplar, the center of the covenant. Through it

the processes of the Administrative order—"this unique, this wondrous

System"—are made to operate.60-5

87 in emphasizing its distinctiveness, Shoghi effendi has pointed out that
 88 "this Administrative order is fundamentally different from anything that
 89 any prophet has previously established, inasmuch as bahá'u'lláh has him-
 90 self revealed its principles, established its institutions, appointed the person to
 interpret his word and conferred the necessary authority on the body

91 60-3. Adj, ¶27 .

92 60-4. gpb, p. 238.60-5. gwb, no. 70.60.5

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105designed to supplement and apply his legislative ordinances.” in another

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statement, he maintains that “it would be utterly misleading to attempt a

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comparison between this unique, divinely conceived order and any of the

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diverse systems which the minds of men, at various periods of their his-

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tory, have contrived for the government of human institutions.” “Such an attempt,” he felt, “would in itself betray a lack of complete appreciation of

the excellence of the handiwork of its great Author.”

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The lack of such appreciation will detract from the perspective of anyone

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who measures bahá’í administrative processes against practices prevalent in

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today’s society. for notwithstanding its inclination to democratic methods

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in the administration of its affairs, and regardless of the resemblance of

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some of its features to those of other systems, the Administrative order is

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not to be viewed merely as an improvement on past and existing systems;

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it represents a departure both in origin and in concept. “This newborn Ad-

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ministrative order,” as Shoghi effendi has explained, “incorporates within

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its structure certain elements which are to be found in each of the three recognized forms of secular government, without being in any sense a mere

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replica of any one of them, and without introducing within its machinery

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any of the objectionable features which they inherently possess. it blends

and harmonizes, as no government fashioned by mortal hands has as yet

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accomplished, the salutary truths which each of these systems undoubt-

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edly contains without vitiating the integrity of those god-given verities on

which it is ultimately founded.”

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you are, no doubt, conversant with the guardian’s expatiations on this

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theme. why, then, this insistent emphasis? why this repeated review of

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fundamentals? This emphasis, this review, is to sound an appeal for solid thinking, for the attainment of correct perspectives, for the adoption of proper attitudes. And these are impossible without a deep appreciation of bahá’í fundamentals.

85 The great emphasis on the distinctiveness of the order of bahá'u'lláh is
 86 not meant to belittle existing systems of government. indeed, they are to be
 87 recognized as the fruit of a vast period of social evolution, representing an advanced
 stage in the development of social organization. what motivates us
 88 is the knowledge that the supreme mission of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh,
 89 60-6. wob, pp. 145, 152.
 90 60-7 . wob, pp. 152-3.60.8

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61 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 62 106the bearer of that order, is, as Shoghi effendi pointed out, "none other
 63 but the achievement of this organic and spiritual unity of the whole body
 64 of nations," indicating the "coming of age of the entire human race."60-8
 65 The astounding implication of this is the near prospect of attaining an age-old hope,
 now made possible at long last by the coming of bahá'u'lláh. in
 66 practical terms, his mission signals the advent of "an organic change in
 67 the structure of present-day society, a change such as the world has not yet
experienced."

68 60-9 it is a fresh manifestation of the direct involvement of god
 69 in history, a reassurance that his children have not been left to drift, a sign
 70 of the outpouring of a heavenly grace that will enable all humanity to be free at last
 from conflict and contention to ascend the heights of world peace and divine civilization.
 beyond all else, it is a demonstration of that love for
 71 his children, which he knew in the depth of his "immemorial being" and
 72 in the "ancient eternity" of his essence, and which caused him to create
 73 us all.
 74 60-10 in the noblest sense, then, attention to the requirements of his
 75 world o r d e r is a reciprocation of that love.

* * *

76 it is this perspective that helps us to understand the question of freedom
 77 and its place in bahá'í thought and action. The idea and the fact of freedom
 78 pervade all human concerns in an infinitude of notions and modes. free-

dom is indeed essential to all expressions of human life.

freedom of thought, freedom of expression, freedom of action are among the freedoms which have received the ardent attention of social thinkers across the centuries. The resulting outflow of such profound thought has exerted a tremendous liberating influence in the shaping of modern society. generations of the oppressed have fought and died in the name of freedom. certainly the want of freedom from oppression has been a dominant factor in the turmoil of the times: witness the plethora of movements which have resulted in the rapid emergence of new nations in the latter part of the twentieth century. A true reading of the teachings of bahá'u'lláh leaves no doubt

60-8. wob, p. 163.

60-9. wob, p. 4360-10. hw , Arabic, no. 3.60.11

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107as to the high importance of these freedoms to constructive social processes. consider, for instance, bahá'u'lláh's proclamation to the kings and rulers. can it not be deduced from this alone that attainment of freedom is a significant purpose of his revelation? his denunciations of tyranny and his urgent appeals on behalf of the oppressed provide unmistakable proof. but does not the freedom foreshadowed by his revelation imply nobler, ampler manifestations of human achievement? does it not indicate an organic relationship between the internal and external realities of man such as has not yet been attained?

in his summary of significant bahá'í teachings, Shoghi effendi wrote that bahá'u'lláh "inculcates the principle of 'moderation in all things'; declares that whatsoever, be it 'liberty, civilization and the like,' 'passeth beyond the limits of moderation' must 'exercise a pernicious influence upon men'; observes that western civilization has gravely perturbed and alarmed the peoples of the world; and predicts that the day is approaching when the 'flame' of a civilization 'carried to excess' 'will devour the cities.'"

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expounding the theme of liberty, bahá'u'lláh asserted that "the embodiment of liberty and its symbol is the animal"; that "liberty causeth man to

77 overstep the bounds of propriety, and to infringe on the dignity of his sta-
78 tion"; that "true liberty consisteth in man's submission unto my command-
79 ments." " we approve of liberty in certain circumstances," he declared,
80 "and refuse to sanction it in others." but he gave the assurance that, " were

men to observe that which we have sent down unto them from the heaven

81 of revelation, they would, of a certainty, attain unto perfect liberty." And
82 again, he said, "m ankind in its entirety must firmly adhere to whatsoever
83 hath been revealed and vouchsafed unto it. Then and only then will it attain

unto true liberty."60-12

84 bahá'u'lláh's assertions clearly call for an examination of current assump-
85 tions. Should liberty be as free as is supposed in contemporary western
86 thought? where does freedom limit our possibilities for progress, and where
87 do limits free us to thrive? what are the limits to the expansion of freedom?
88 for so fluid and elastic are its qualities of application and expression that the
89 concept of freedom in any given situation is likely to assume a different lati-tude
from one mind to another; these qualities are, alas, susceptible to the

90 60-11. gpb, p. 218.

91 60-12. kA, ¶123, 125, 124, 125; Tb, p. 89.60.13

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61 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

62 108employment alike of good and evil. is it any wonder, then, that bahá'u'lláh
63 exhorts us to submission to the will of g od?

64 Since any constructive view of freedom implies limits, further questions
65 are inevitable: what are the latitudes of freedom in the bahá'í community?
66 how are these to be determined? because human beings have been created
67 to "carry forward an ever-advancing civilization," the exercise of freedom,
68 it may be deduced, is intended to enable all to fulfill this purpose in their
69 individual lives and in their collective functioning as a society.60-13 hence
70 whatever in principle is required to realize this purpose gauges the latitudes
71 or limits of freedom.

contemplating bahá'u'lláh's warning that "whatsoever passeth beyond

72 the limits of moderation will cease to exert a beneficial influence,"60-14 we
73 come to appreciate that the Administrative order he has conceived embod-
74 ies the operating principles which are necessary to the maintenance of that
75 moderation which will ensure the "true liberty" of humankind. All things considered,
does the Administrative order not appear to be the structure
76 of freedom for our Age? 'Abdu'l-b ahá offers us comfort in this thought, for
77 he has said that "the moderate freedom which guarantees the welfare of the
78 world of mankind and maintains and preserves the universal relationships is found
in its fullest power and extension in the teachings of bahá'u'lláh."

79 60-15

80 within this framework of freedom a pattern is set for institutional and
81 individual behavior which depends for its efficacy not so much on the force
82 of law, which admittedly must be respected, as on the recognition of a
83 mutuality of benefits, and on the spirit of cooperation maintained by the willingness,
the courage, the sense of responsibility, and the initiative of individuals—these being
expressions of their devotion and submission to
84 the will of god. Thus there is a balance of freedom between the institution,
85 whether national or local, and the individuals who sustain its existence.
86 consider, for example, the local Spiritual Assembly, the methods of its
87 formation and the role of individuals in electing it. The voter elects with the
understanding that he is free to choose without any interference whomever
88 his conscience prompts him to select, and he freely accepts the authority of the
outcome. in the act of voting, the individual subscribes to a covenant

89 60-13. gwb, no. 109.2.

90 60-14. gwb, no. 110.60-15. Swb, no. 227 .27 .60.16

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62 109by which the orderliness of society is upheld. The Assembly has the respon-
63 sibility to guide, direct and decide on community affairs and the right to be

obeyed and supported by members of the community. The individual has

64 the responsibility to establish and maintain the Assembly through election, the
offering of advice, moral support and material assistance; and he has the right to be heard by
it, to receive its guidance and assistance, and to
65 appeal from any Assembly decision which he conscientiously feels is unjust
66 or detrimental to the interests of the community.

but occupation with the mechanics of bahá'í Administration, divorced

67 from the animating spirit of the cause, leads to a distortion, to an arid
68 secularization foreign to the nature of the Administration. equally signifi-
69 cant to the procedures for election—to further extend the example—is the evocation
of that rarefied atmosphere of prayer and reflection, that quiet
70 dignity of the process, devoid of nominations and campaigning, in which
71 the individual's freedom to choose is limited only by his own conscience, exercised in
private in an attitude that invites communion with the holy
72 Spirit. in this sphere, the elector regards the outcome as an expression of the
73 will of god, and those elected as being primarily responsible to that will,
74 not to the constituency which elected them. An election thus conducted portrays an
aspect of that organic unity of the inner and outer realities of human life which is necessary
to the construction of a mature society in
75 this new Age. in no other system do individuals exercise such a breadth of
76 freedom in the electoral process.

* * *

The equilibrium of responsibilities implied by all this presupposes

77 maturity on the part of all concerned. This maturity has an apt analogy
78 in adulthood in human beings. how significant is the difference between
79 infancy and childhood, adolescence and adulthood! in a period of history
80 dominated by the surging energy, the rebellious spirit and frenetic activ-
81 ity of adolescence, it is difficult to grasp the distinguishing elements of
82 the mature society to which bahá'u'lláh beckons all humanity. The models
83 of the old world order blur vision of that which must be perceived; for
84 these models were, in many instances, conceived in rebellion and retain the
85 characteristics of the revolutions peculiar to an adolescent, albeit necessary, period in
the evolution of human society. The very philosophies which have 60.20

61 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
62 110 provided the intellectual content of such revolutions—h obbes, locke, jef-
63 ferson, mill come readily to mind—were inspired by protest against the
64 oppressive conditions which revolutions were intended to remedy.

These characteristics are conspicuous, for example, in the inordinate

65 skepticism regarding authority, and consequently, in the grudging respect
66 which the citizens of various nations show toward their governments; they
67 have become pronounced in the incessant promotion of individualism,
68 often to the detriment of the wider interests of society. how aptly, even
69 after the lapse of half a century, Shoghi effendi's views, as conveyed by his
70 secretary, fit the contemporary scene: "o ur present generation, mainly due
71 to the corruptions that have been identified with organizations, seem to stand against
any institution. religion as an institution is denounced. gov-
72 ernment as an institution is denounced. even marriage as an institution is
73 denounced. we bahá'ís should not be blinded by such prevalent notions. if
74 such were the case, all the divine manifestations would not have invariably

appointed someone to succeed Them. undoubtedly, corruptions did enter

75 those institutions, but these corruptions were not due to the very nature of
76 the institutions but to the lack of proper directions as to their powers and
77 nature of their perpetuation. what bahá'u'lláh has done is not to eliminate
78 all institutions in the cause but to provide the necessary safeguards that
79 would eliminate corruptions that caused the fall of previous institutions.
80 what those safeguards are is most interesting to study and find out and also

most essential to know."

81 we make these observations not to indulge in criticism of any system,
82 but rather to open up lines of thought, to encourage a reexamination of the bases of
modern society, and to engender a perspective for consideration of the distinctive features of
the order of bahá'u'lláh. what, it could be asked,
83 was the nature of society that gave rise to such characteristics and such
84 philosophies? where have these taken mankind? has their employment sat-
85 isfied the needs and expectations of the human spirit? The answers to such

86 questions could lay the ground for a contrasting observation of the origin and nature
of the characteristics and philosophy underlying that order.

* * *

87 As to freedom of expression, a fundamental principle of the cause, the
88 Administrative order provides unique methods and channels for its exercise 60.22

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62 111and maintenance; these have been amply described in the writings of the
63 faith, but they are not yet clearly understood by the friends. for bahá'u'lláh
64 has extended the scope and deepened the meaning of self-expression. in his

65 elevation of art and of work performed in the service of humanity to acts of worship
can be discerned enormous prospects for a new birth of expression in the civilization
anticipated by his world order. The significance of

66 this principle, now so greatly amplified by the lord of the Age, cannot be

67 doubted; but it is in its ramifications in speech that keen understanding is urgently
needed. from a bahá'í point of view, the exercise of freedom of

68 speech must necessarily be disciplined by a profound appreciation of both
69 the positive and negative dimensions of freedom, on the one hand, and of
70 speech, on the other.

71 bahá'u'lláh warns us that “the tongue is a smoldering fire, and excess of
72 speech a deadly poison.” “material fire consumeth the body,” he says in

73 elaborating the point, “whereas the fire of the tongue devoureth both heart and soul.
The force of the former lasteth but for a time, whilst the effects of the latter endureth a
century.” in tracing the framework of free speech, he

74 again advises “moderation.” “human utterance is an essence which aspireth

75 to exert its influence and needeth moderation,” he states, adding, “As to its

76 influence, this is conditional upon refinement which in turn is dependent upon hearts
which are detached and pure. As to its moderation, this hath

77 to be combined with tact and wisdom as prescribed in the holy Scriptures

and Tablets.”

78 60-16

79 Also relevant to what is said, and how, is when it is said. for speech,

80 as for so many other things, there is a season. bahá'u'lláh reinforces this
81 understanding by drawing attention to the maxim that "Not everything that
82 a man knoweth can be disclosed, nor can everything that he can disclose be regarded
as timely, nor can every timely utterance be considered as suited to the capacity of those who
hear it."

83 60-17

84 Speech is a powerful phenomenon. its freedom is both to be extolled and
85 feared. it calls for an acute exercise of judgment, since both the limitation
86 of speech and the excess of it can lead to dire consequences. Thus there exist in the
system of bahá'u'lláh checks and balances necessary to the beneficial

87 60-16. ki, ¶213; Tb, p. 143

88 60-17 . gwb, no. 89.3.60.25

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62 112uses of this freedom in the onward development of society. A careful exami-
63 nation of the principles of bahá'í consultation and the formal and informal
64 arrangements for employing them offer new insights into the dynamics of freedom of
expression.

65 As it is beyond the scope of this letter to expatiate upon these principles,
66 let it suffice to recall briefly certain of the requisites of consultation, par-
67 ticularly for those who serve on Spiritual Assemblies. love and harmony,
68 purity of motive, humility and lowliness amongst the friends, patience and
69 long-suffering in difficulties—these inform the attitude with which they proceed
"with the utmost devotion, courtesy, dignity, care and moderation
70 to express their views," each using "perfect liberty" both in so doing and in
71 "unveiling the proof of his demonstration." "i f another contradicts him, he
72 must not become excited because if there be no investigation or verification
73 of questions and matters, the agreeable view will not be discovered neither
74 understood." "The shining spark of truth cometh forth only after the clash of
differing opinions." if unanimity is not subsequently achieved, decisions
75 are arrived at by majority vote.

76 60-18

77 once a decision has been reached, all members of the consultative body,
78 having had the opportunity fully to state their views, agree wholeheartedly
79 to support the outcome. what if the minority view is right? “i f they agree
80 upon a subject,” ‘Abdu’l-b ahá has explained, “even though it be wrong, it is
81 better than to disagree and be in the right, for this difference will produce
82 the demolition of the divine foundation. Though one of the parties may be
83 in the right and they disagree, that will be the cause of a thousand wrongs,
84 but if they agree and both parties are in the wrong, as it is in unity, the truth will be
revealed and the wrong made right.”

85 60-19 implicit in this approach to
86 the social utility of thought is the profundity of the change in the standard
87 of public discussion intended by b ahá’u’lláh for a mature society.
88 The qualities by which the individual can achieve the personal discipline
89 necessary to successful consultation find their full expression in what Shoghi
90 effendi regarded as the “spirit of a true bahá’í.” ponder, for instance, the ap-
91 pealing remark addressed to your own community in one of his earliest let-ters:
“Nothing short of the spirit of a true bahá’í can hope to reconcile the

92 principles of mercy and justice, of freedom and submission, of the sanctity

93 60-18. Sw Ab, no. 45; bwf , p. 406; Sw Ab, no. 44.

94 60-19. bwf , p. 411.60.28

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62 11of the right of the individual and of self-surrender, of vigilance, discretion
63 and prudence on the one hand, and fellowship, candor, and courage on the
64 other.”60-20 This was an appeal to the maturity and the distinction towards
65 which he repeatedly directed their thoughts.

* * *

because the most great peace is the object of our longing, a primary

66 effort of the bahá’í community is to reduce the incidence of conflict and

67 contention, which are categorically forbidden in the most holy book. does

68 this mean that one may not express critical thought? Absolutely not. how
 69 can there be the candor called for in consultation if there is no critical
 70 thought? how is the individual to exercise his responsibilities to the cause,
 71 if he is not allowed the freedom to express his views? has Shoghi effendi
 72 not stated that “at the very root of the cause lies the principle of the un-
 73 doubted right of the individual to self-expression, his freedom to declare his
 conscience and set forth his views”?

74 60-21

75 The Administrative order provides channels for expression of criticism,
 76 acknowledging, as a matter of principle, that “it is not only the right, but
 77 the vital responsibility of every loyal and intelligent member of the com-
 78 munity to offer fully and frankly, but with due respect and consideration to the
 authority of the Assembly, any suggestion, recommendation or criticism he conscientiously
 feels he should in order to improve and remedy certain
 79 existing conditions or trends in his local community.” correspondingly,
 80 the Assembly has the duty “to give careful consideration to any such views

submitted to them.”

81 60-22

82 Apart from the direct access which one has to an Assembly, local or na-
 83 tional, or to a counselor or Auxiliary board member, there are specific occa-
 84 sions for the airing of one’s views in the community. The most frequent of these
 occasions for any bahá’í is the Nineteen day feast which, “besides its

85 social and spiritual aspects, fulfills various administrative needs and require-ments of
 the community, chief among them being the need for open and

86 constructive criticism and deliberation regarding the state of affairs within

87 60-20. bA, pp. 63–64.

88 60-21. bA, p. 63.60-22. lg, no. 288.60.31

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62 11the local bahá’í community.” At the same time, Shoghi effendi’s advice, as
 63 conveyed by his secretary, goes on to stress the point that “all criticisms and

64 discussions of a negative character which may result in undermining the au-
65 thority of the Assembly as a body should be strictly avoided. for otherwise
66 the order of the cause itself will be endangered, and confusion and discord

will reign in the community.”60-23

67 clearly, then, there is more to be considered than the critic’s right to self-
68 expression; the unifying spirit of the cause of god must also be preserved,
69 the authority of its laws and ordinances safeguarded, authority being an
indispensable aspect of freedom. motive, manner, mode, become relevant;

70 but there is also the matter of love: love for one’s fellows, love for one’s com-munity,
love for one’s institutions.

71 The responsibility resting on the individual to conduct himself in such
72 a way as to ensure the stability of society takes on elemental importance in this
context. for vital as it is to the progress of society, criticism is a two-

73 edged sword: it is all too often the harbinger of conflict and contention. The
74 balanced processes of the Administrative order are meant to prevent this es-
75 sential activity from degenerating to any form of dissent that breeds opposi-
76 tion and its dreadful schismatic consequences. how incalculable have been

77 the negative results of ill-directed criticism: in the catastrophic divergences it has
created in religion, in the equally contentious factions it has spawned in political systems,
which have dignified conflict by institutionalizing such concepts as the “loyal opposition”
which attach to one or another of the

78 various categories of political opinion—conservative, liberal, progressive,
79 reactionary, and so forth.

80 if bahá’í individuals deliberately ignore the principles imbedded in the
81 order which bahá’u’lláh himself has established to remedy divisiveness in
82 the human family, the cause for which so much has been sacrificed will

83 surely be set back in its mission to rescue world society from complete
dis-integration. may not the existence of the covenant be invoked again and

84 again, so that such repetition may preserve the needed perspective? for, in
85 this age, the cause of bahá’u’lláh has been protected against the baneful

86 effects of the misuse of the process of criticism; this has been done by the in-stitution
of the covenant and by the provision of a universal administrative

87 60-23. lg, no. 28860.34

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62 115system which incorporates within itself the mechanisms for drawing out the

63 constructive ideas of individuals and using them for the benefit of the entire

system. Admonishing the people to uphold the unifying purpose of the

64 cause, bahá'u'lláh, in the book of his covenant, addresses these poignant

65 words to them: “let not the means of order be made the cause of confusion and the instrument of union an occasion for discord.”

66 60-24 Such assertions

67 emphasize a crucial point; it is this: in terms of the covenant, dissidence

68 is a moral and intellectual contradiction of the main objective animating the bahá'í community, namely, the establishment of the unity of mankind.

* * *

69 we return to the phenomenal characteristics of speech. content, volume,

70 style, tact, wisdom, timeliness are among the critical factors in determining the effects of speech for good or evil. consequently, the friends need ever

71 to be conscious of the significance of this activity which so distinguishes

72 human beings from other forms of life, and they must exercise it judiciously.

73 Their efforts at such discipline will give birth to an etiquette of expression worthy of the approaching maturity of the human race. just as this disci-

74 pline applies to the spoken word, it applies equally to the written word; and

75 it profoundly affects the operation of the press.

The significance and role of the press in a new world system are con-

76 spicuous in the emphasis which the order of bahá'u'lláh places on acces-

77 sibility to information at all levels of society. Shoghi effendi tells us that

78 bahá'u'lláh makes “specific reference to ‘the swiftly appearing newspapers,’

79 describes them as ‘the mirror of the world’ and as ‘an amazing and potent

80 phenomenon,’ and prescribes to all who are responsible for their production

81 the duty to be sanctified from malice, passion and prejudice, to be just and

82 fair-minded, to be painstaking in their inquiries, and ascertain all the facts in every situation.”

83 60-25

84 in his social treatise, The Secret of Divine Civilization, ‘Abdu’l-bahá of-
85 fers insight as to the indispensability of the press in future society. he says
86 it is “urgent that beneficial articles and books be written, clearly and defi-
87 60-24. Tb, p. 222.

88 60-25. gpb, p. 219.60.37

60 38

60 39

61 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

62 116nitely establishing what the present-day requirements of the people are, and
63 what will conduce to the happiness and advancement of society.” further,
64 he writes of the “publication of high thoughts” as the “dynamic power in
65 the arteries of life,” “the very soul of the world.” moreover, he states that
66 “public opinion must be directed toward whatever is worthy of this day, and
67 this is impossible except through the use of adequate arguments and the

adducing of clear, comprehensive and conclusive proofs.”60-26

As to manner and style, bahá’u’lláh has exhorted “authors among the

68 friends” to “write in such a way as would be acceptable to fair-minded souls, and not
lead to caviling by the people.” And he issues a reminder: “ we

69 have said in the past that one word hath the influence of spring and causeth

70 hearts to become fresh and verdant, while another is like unto blight which causeth
the blossoms and flowers to wither.”

71 60-27

72 in the light of all this, the code of conduct of the press must embrace the

73 principles and objectives of consultation as revealed by bahá’u’lláh. only in

74 this way will the press be able to make its full contribution to the preserva-tion of the
rights of the people and become a powerful instrument in the consultative processes of
society, and hence for the unity of the human race.

* * *

Some of the friends have suggested that the emergence of the faith

75 from obscurity indicates the timeliness of ceasing observance in the bahá’í

76 community of certain restraints; particularly are they concerned about the temporary
necessity of review before publishing.

77 That the faith has emerged from obscurity on a global scale is certain.

78 This definitely marks a triumphant stage in the efforts of the community to register
its existence on the minds of those who influence world events. consider how, because of the
sufferings and sacrifices of the friends in iran,

79 the concerns of the community in these respects have become a matter of discussion
in the most influential parliaments and the most important in-ternational forums on earth.
That this emergence frees the cause to pursue

80 60-26. Sdc, pp. 109–10.

81 60-27 . cc 2:407 .60.40

60 41

60 42

60 43

61 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

62 117objectives hitherto unreachable is also undeniable; but that it marks the

63 attainment of the community’s anticipated maturity is entirely doubtful.

64 how could it have attained maturity, when we know from the clear guid-

65 ance of the beloved guardian that obscurity is but one of the many stages

66 in the long evolution towards the faith’s golden destiny? has he not advised

67 us all that the subsequent stage of oppression must precede the stages of its

68 emancipation and its recognition as a world religion? can the friends forget

69 the oft-quoted warning of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá concerning the bitter opposition

70 that will confront the cause in various lands on all continents? in the case

71 of the American believers, has Shoghi effendi not alluded to this coming

72 fury in his description of them as “the invincible Army of bahá’u’lláh, who

73 in the west, and at one of its potential storm centers is to fight, in his name

74 and for h is sake, one of its fiercest and most glorious battles”?60-28

Those who are anxious to relax all restraint, who invoke freedom of

75 speech as the rationale for publishing every and any thing concerning the bahá’í
community, who call for the immediate termination of the practice

of review now that the faith has emerged from obscurity—are they not

76 aware of these sobering prospects? widespread as has been the public revul-

77 sion to the current persecutions in iran, let there be no mistake about the
 78 certainty of the opposition which must yet be confronted in many coun-
 79 tries, including that which is the c radle of the Administrative o rder itself.
 80 The faith is as yet in its infancy. despite its emergence from obscurity,
 81 even now the vast majority of the human race remains ignorant of its exis-
 82 tence; moreover, the vast majority of its adherents are relatively new bahá'ís.
 83 The change implied by this new stage in its evolution is that whereas here-
 84 tofore this tender plant was protected in its obscurity from the attention
 85 of external elements, it has now become exposed. This exposure invites
 86 close observation, and that observation will eventually lead to opposition in various
 quarters. So, far from adopting a carefree attitude, the community must be conscious of the
 necessity to present a correct view of itself and an
 87 accurate understanding of its purpose to a largely skeptical public. A greater
 88 effort, a greater care must now be exercised to ensure its protection against the malice
 of the ignorant and the unwisdom of its friends.

89 60-28. Adj, ¶60.60.44

60 45

60 46

61 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

62 118let us all remember that the struggle of the infant faith of god to thrive
 63 is beset with the turmoil of the present age. like a tender shoot just barely
 64 discernible above ground, it must be nurtured to strength and maturity
 65 and buttressed as necessary against the blight of strong winds and deadly
 entanglements with weeds and thistles. if we to whose care this plant has
 66 been entrusted are insensitive to its tenderness, the great tree which is its
 67 certain potential will be hindered in its growth towards the spreading of
 68 its sheltering branches over all humankind. from this perspective we must
 69 all consider the latent danger to the cause of ill-advised actions and exag-
 70 gerated expectations; and particularly must we all be concerned about the
 71 effects of words, especially those put in print. it is here that bahá'í authors
 72 and publishers need to be attentive and exert rigorous discipline upon them-
 73 selves, as well as abide by the requirements of review at this early stage in the

74 development of the faith.

* * *

75 The right of the individual to self-expression has permeated the forego-

ing comments on the various freedoms, but, even so, a word more might

76 be said about individual freedom. The fundamental attitude of the faith in
77 this respect is best demonstrated by statements of ‘Abdu’l-bahá concerning
78 the family. “The integrity of the family bond,” he says, “must be constantly
79 considered, and the rights of the individual members must not be trans-
80 gressed. . . . All these rights and prerogatives must be conserved, yet the
81 unity of the family must be sustained. The injury of one shall be considered
82 the injury of all; the comfort of each, the comfort of all; the honor of one, the honor of
all.”

83 60-29

84 The individual’s relation to society is explained by Shoghi effendi in the
85 statement that “The bahá’í conception of social life is essentially based on
86 the principle of the subordination of the individual will to that of society. it neither
suppresses the individual nor does it exalt him to the point of
87 making him an anti-social creature, a menace to society. As in everything, it follows
the ‘golden mean.’”

88 60-30

89 60-29. pup , pp. 232–33.

90 60-30. dg, p. 53.60.47

60 48

60 49

61 1986–1992 • The Six Year Plan

62 119This relationship, so fundamental to the maintenance of civilized life,
63 calls for the utmost degree of understanding and cooperation between so-
64 ciety and the individual; and because of the need to foster a climate in

65 which the untold potentialities of the individual members of society can develop, this
relationship must allow “free scope” for “individuality to assert itself” through modes of
spontaneity, initiative and diversity that ensure the

66 viability of society. Among the responsibilities assigned to bahá’í institu-

67 tions which have a direct bearing on these aspects of individual freedom
68 and development is one which is thus described in the constitution of the
69 universal house of justice: “to safeguard the personal rights, freedom and
70 initiative of individuals.” A corollary is: “to give attention to the preserva-tion of
human honor.”

71 60-31

how noteworthy that in the order of bahá'u'lláh, while the individual

72 will is subordinated to that of society, the individual is not lost in the mass
73 but becomes the focus of primary development, so that he may find his own
74 place in the flow of progress, and society as a whole may benefit from the
accumulated talents and abilities of the individuals composing it. Such an individual finds
fulfillment of his potential not merely in satisfying his own
75 wants but in realizing his completeness in being at one with humanity and
76 with the divinely ordained purpose of creation.
77 The quality of freedom and of its expression—indeed, the very capacity

to maintain freedom in a society—undoubtedly depends on the knowl-

78 edge and training of individuals and on their ability to cope with the chal-
79 lenges of life with equanimity. As the beloved master has written: “And the
80 honor and distinction of the individual consist in this, that he among all
81 the world’s multitudes should become a source of social good. is any larger
82 bounty conceivable than this, that an individual, looking within himself,
83 should find that by the confirming grace of god he has become the cause of
84 peace and well-being, of happiness and advantage to his fellowmen? No, by
85 the one true g od, there is no greater bliss, no more complete delight.”

86 60-32

* * *

87 The spirit of liberty which in recent decades has swept over the planet
88 with such tempestuous force is a manifestation of the vibrancy of the rev-
89 60-31. cuhj, p. 5.

90 60-32. Sdc, pp. 2–3.60.50

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60 52

60 53

61 m e S S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

62 120elation brought by bahá'u'lláh. his own words confirm it. "The Ancient

63 beauty," he wrote in a soul-stirring commentary on his sufferings, "hath

64 consented to be bound with chains that mankind may be released from its

65 bondage, and hath accepted to be made a prisoner within this most mighty
Stronghold that the whole world may attain unto true liberty."

66 60-33

67 might it not be reasonably concluded, then, that "true liberty" is his gift

68 of love to the human race? consider what bahá'u'lláh has done: he revealed

69 laws and principles to guide the free; he established an order to channel

70 the actions of the free; he proclaimed a covenant to guarantee the unity

71 of the free.

72 Thus, we hold to this ultimate perspective: bahá'u'lláh came to set hu-

73 manity free. his revelation is, indeed, an invitation to freedom—freedom

74 from want, freedom from war, freedom to unite, freedom to progress, free-dom in
peace and joy.

75 you who live in a land where freedom is so highly prized have not, then,

76 to dispense with its fruits, but you are challenged and do have the obliga-tion to
uphold and vindicate the distinction between the license that limits your possibilities for
genuine progress and the moderation that ensures the

77 enjoyment of true liberty.

78 61

External Affairs Consultations

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]